



Importing Photos into Lightroom Classic

From OneDrive to your Catalog, step by step.

1. Check OneDrive

2. Open Lightroom

3. Click Import

4. Find Your Folder

5. Confirm Import

6. Create Collection

Lightroom Does Not Move Your Photos

Lightroom Classic uses a Catalog. The catalog remembers where your photos are and tracks your edits. Your actual photo files stay exactly where you put them on OneDrive.

The Catalog

A database file inside Lightroom

Tracks where your photos live

Remembers every edit you make

Does not contain your actual photo files

Your Photo Files

Live inside OneDrive.

Path: OneDrive-SantaMariaJUHSD

> Photography

> Your Project Folder

Check OneDrive First



Do this before opening Lightroom. If your photos are not fully synced, Lightroom cannot find them.

1

Find the OneDrive icon

Look in the bottom-right corner of your screen in the System Tray.

2

It should show a green checkmark

White or blue cloud icon with a checkmark = you are good to go.

Red X or yellow triangle = there is an error. Fix it before continuing.

3

Wait if it is still syncing

A spinning icon means OneDrive is still working. Wait until it stops and shows a green checkmark.

4

Confirm your folder in File Explorer

Open File Explorer. Go to OneDrive-SantaMariaJUHSD > Photography > your project folder. Make sure your image files are there.

Open Lightroom Classic

 **Open Lightroom Classic, not the regular Lightroom app. The correct icon LrC not just LR.**

1

Click the Windows Start button

Press the Windows key and type Lightroom Classic in the search bar.

2

Click to open it

Click the icon that says Classic underneath. It may take 15 to 30 seconds to fully load.

3

Make sure you are in the Library module

At the top right of Lightroom, confirm Library is highlighted in the module picker. If not, click it.

**Adobe
Lightroom
Classic**

Artwork by Molly Matalon.

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Reading preferences...

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Library | Develop | Map | Book | Slides

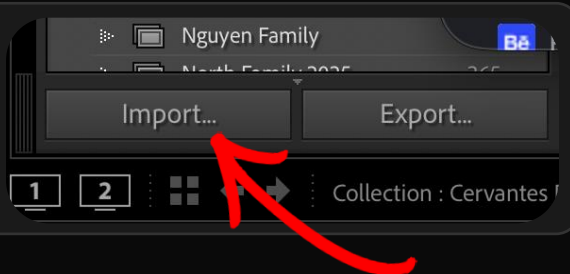
STEP 03

Click the Import Button

The Import Dialog is the window where you tell Lightroom which photos to bring into your catalog.

Click the Import button at the bottom-left of the Library module.

It is always visible in the bottom-left corner. This opens the Import Dialog.



The Import Dialog has three sections:

LEFT

Source

Browse to find your photo files.

CENTER

Preview

Preview the photos before importing.

RIGHT

Options

File handling and metadata options.

Find Your Project Folder

Use the Source panel on the LEFT side of the Import Dialog. Follow this path exactly

1

 **OneDrive - SantaMariaJUHSD**

Scroll down in the Source panel until you see this folder. Click the arrow ► to expand it.

2

 **Photography**

Click the arrow ► next to Photography to expand it. Your project folders will appear inside.

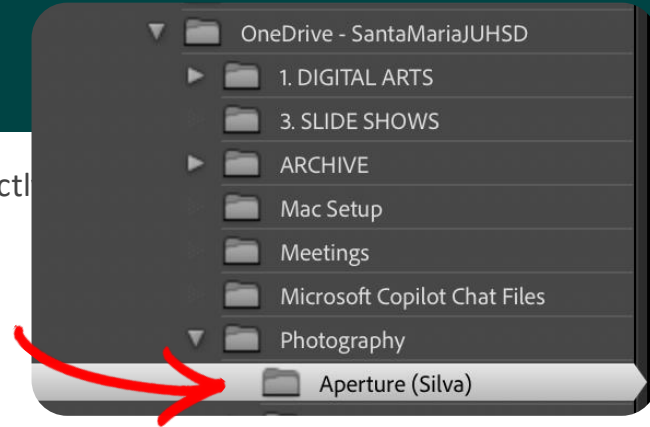
3

 **Your Project Folder**

Click on your project folder once to SELECT it. Do not just expand it with the arrow.



Thumbnails will appear in the center of the Import Dialog once you have selected the correct folder.



STEP 05

Import All Your Photos

Import everything. You will review and select your best images later during the culling process.

ADD is already selected at the top of the Import Dialog.

This tells Lightroom where your photos are without moving or copying them. Leave it set to ADD.

Before clicking Import, confirm these three settings in the RIGHT panel:



Build Previews: **Standard**

Lightroom builds good quality previews. Standard is the right choice for class work.



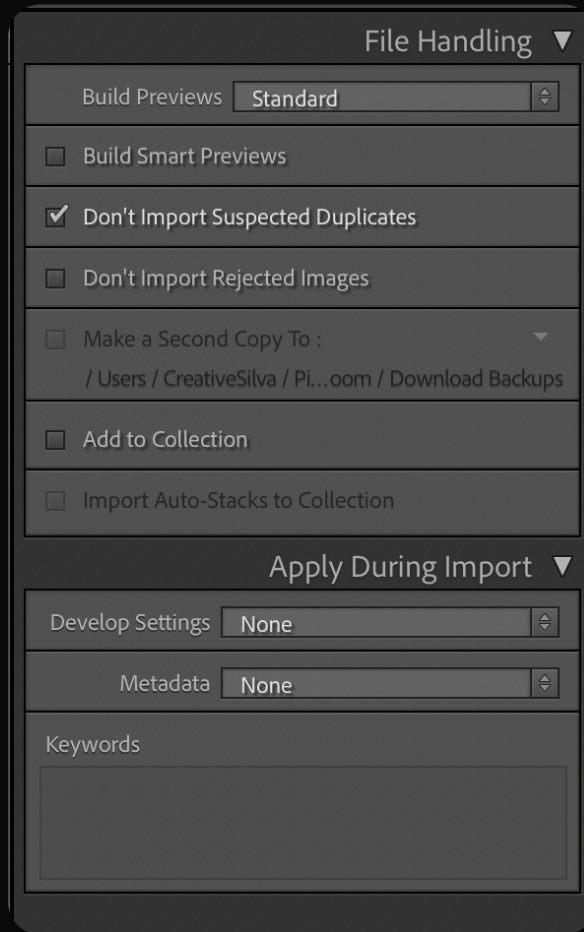
Don't Import Suspected Duplicates: **Checked ON**

Prevents the same photo from being imported twice if you import this folder again.

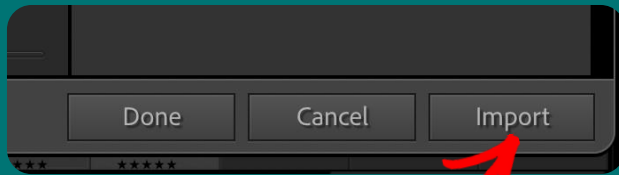


Add to Collection: **Leave unchecked**

You will create the Collection manually after import. Leave this unchecked.



Click Import and Confirm It Worked



Click Import at the bottom-right of the dialog. Then take 30 seconds to confirm it worked.

How to confirm it worked:

1

Look at the bottom-left corner

Look at the Folders panel on the left side of the Library module. You will see a number next to your project folder. That is your imported image count.

2

Cross-reference with File Explorer

Open File Explorer and check how many files are in your project folder. That number should match the count in Lightroom exactly.

3

Press G for Grid view, then E for Loupe View (toggle back and forth)

You will see all your imported photos as thumbnails. Scan through quickly to confirm they all look right. Then **press E** to go to single image “Loupe View” and then **press G** to go back to grid view.



Import Successful

Folder in Library shows the correct image count.
Grid view shows thumbnails.
Numbers match File Explorer.



Photos Not Showing?

A question mark on a photo means Lightroom cannot find the file.

Make sure you didn't move or rename the source folder. Check that OneDrive finished syncing before you imported.

What is a Collection and What to Name It

A Collection is a virtual album inside Lightroom. It groups your photos for easy access without moving the actual files. Name it clearly so you can find it months from now.

✓ Good Names

Natural Light Portraits

Sauce Baby Product Photos

Campus Architecture Project

Street Photography 2026

Black and White Textures

✗ Avoid These

"photos" Too vague.

"final" Final of what?

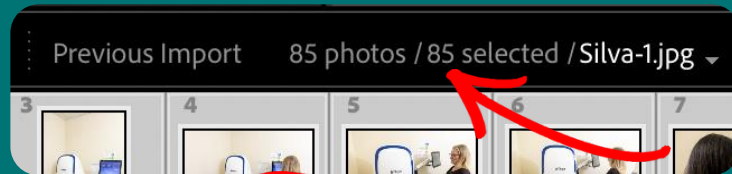
"new folder 1" No information.

"asdfgh" Can't find it later.

"stuff" Not professional.

Create Your Collection

You are now back in the Library module. Your imported images are showing in Grid



Press Ctrl + A (Win) or Command + A (Mac)

This selects **ALL** of the images you just imported. You should see every thumbnail highlighted. Check the count at the bottom of the screen, for example, 43 selected. This should match the number you imported.

Find the Collections panel on the left

Scroll down the left panel in the Library module until you see the Collections panel with a small + icon next to it.

Click + and choose Create Collection

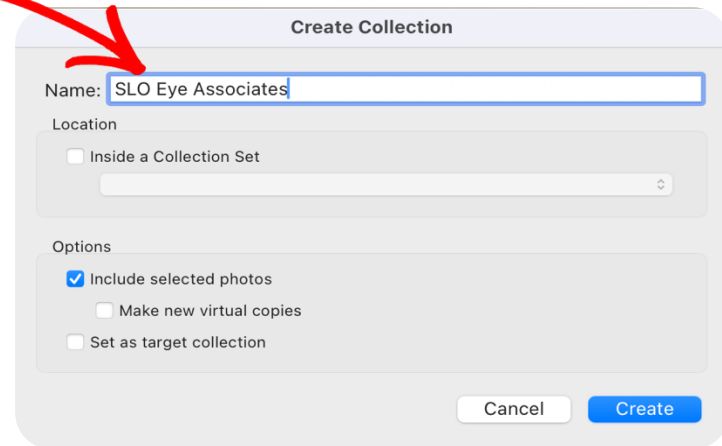
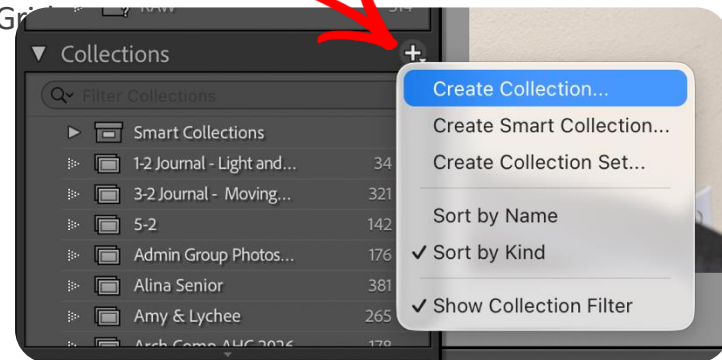
A small dropdown will appear. Choose Create Collection.

Name your Collection in the dialog

Type the name you decided on, for example: Natural Light Portraits. Make sure Include Selected Photos is checked.

Click Create

Your new Collection appears in the Collections panel on the left. Click it to confirm all your project images are inside.



Your Complete Workflow

Follow this every time you start a new project.

01

Check OneDrive

Green checkmark in taskbar. No errors.

03

Click Import

Bottom-left of the Library module.

05

Click Import

Import everything. You will cull and select your best images later.

07

Ctrl/Cmd + A, then Create Collection

Select all > Collections panel > + > Create Collection.

02

Open Lightroom Classic

Look for Classic under the icon. Not the regular Lightroom app.

04

Navigate to your folder

OneDrive-SantaMariaJUHSD > Photography > project folder.

06

Confirm the count

Folder count in Library must match your source folder count in File Explorer.

08

Name your Collection

Clear, descriptive name. Example: Natural Light Portraits.



Your Import is Complete.

Your photos are in your catalog. Your Collection is created. You are now ready to edit.

YOUR NEXT STEP



Head to the Develop Module to Start Editing

Click Develop in the module picker at the top right. Open your Collection and start working through your images.

Remember: Press D to go to Develop | Press G for Grid view | Press E for Loope View | Press L to go to Library